JA BizTown Request for Proposal

Vendor Question Responses

March 27, 2026

This document provides responses to questions submitted by prospective respondents during the RFP process. The clarifications and information included are intended to support a shared understanding of the RFP requirements and to ensure consistent interpretation across all interested parties.

1. Outcome-Based Success Criteria and Measurement Framework

How does JA define measurable success for the BizTown simulation redevelopment—both in terms of student learning outcomes (e.g., financial literacy gains, civic engagement indicators) and operational performance (e.g., simulation uptime, staff efficiency)? Will JA partner with us to establish baseline metrics during Discovery and track them through pilot and beyond launch?

JA Response: JA defines measurable success for the JA BizTown simulation redevelopment across both student learning outcomes and operational performance.

From a student impact perspective, our primary goal is for participants to leave their JA BizTown experience with a deeper understanding of teamwork, how businesses operate, and the value of every role within an organization. We aim to see measurable growth in financial literacy at both the personal and business levels, as well as increased confidence in applying those concepts in real-world scenarios. Additionally, we prioritize outcomes related to character development, including ethical decision-making, responsibility, and effective collaboration. These outcomes may be assessed through a combination of pre- and post-experience evaluations, educator feedback, and student self-reflection.

From an operational standpoint, success is defined by a seamless and reliable simulation experience. This includes minimal to no system lag, strong and stable connectivity between student devices and administrative controls, and smooth integration across all components of the simulation. Efficiency for staff is also critical, with intuitive systems that streamline facilitation and reduce manual intervention.

JA fully intends to partner with the selected vendor to establish baseline metrics during the Discovery phase and collaboratively define key performance indicators. We expect to track these metrics through pilot implementation and beyond launch to ensure continuous improvement and long-term success.

2. Discovery Phase Scope and Decision Authority

The RFP references several items to be "determined during Discovery," including XP point weighting, gamification scope, AI feature boundaries, security standards, and admin role definitions. Can JA clarify the expected duration and structure of the Discovery phase, and confirm that the selected vendor will have direct access to stakeholders with decision-making authority to finalize these open requirements? Additionally, how does JA envision managing scope changes that emerge from Discovery findings?

JA Response: JA's Discovery phase is already actively underway and is a critical component of our preparation for the BizTown redevelopment. This phase primarily consists of JA USA staff conducting site visits to observe JA BizTown programs across the country, as well as facilitating strategy sessions with local JA Area staff. These efforts are focused on gathering insights related to the overall program experience, simulation design, and supporting software systems.

We anticipate that this Discovery work will be substantially complete by the time a vendor is selected. At that point, we will have a well-informed set of requirements and priorities that will allow us to move efficiently into design and development. While JA has defined core requirements for the simulation, we fully expect to collaborate closely with the selected vendor to refine how those requirements are best executed—particularly in areas such as gamification, AI feature boundaries, and system design.

The selected vendor will have direct access to key JA USA stakeholders, including individuals with decision-making authority, to ensure alignment and timely resolution of open questions. We view this as a highly collaborative partnership and will prioritize consistent communication and structured touchpoints throughout the project.

Regarding scope management, JA intends to establish a clear governance process in partnership with the vendor. This will include prioritization of features, documentation of agreed-upon requirements, and a structured approach to evaluating and approving any scope changes that emerge from Discovery insights or early development phases. Our goal is to remain flexible where it adds value, while maintaining alignment with project timelines, budget, and overall objectives.

3. AI Strategy and Integration Roadmap

The RFP mentions AI-generated business slogans and CEO speech transcription as specific features, and the previous Finance Park RFP referenced an AI chatbot API that JA is developing independently. Can JA outline the broader AI strategy for BizTown—including which AI capabilities JA expects the vendor to build versus integrate, what guardrails exist for age-appropriate AI interactions with 5th–6th graders, and whether there is appetite for AI-infused

capabilities beyond what is listed (such as adaptive difficulty, intelligent tutoring prompts, or predictive analytics for staff dashboards)?

JA Response: JA's approach to AI within the JA BizTown simulation is intentionally targeted, age-appropriate, and closely aligned to the educational goals of the program.

At this time, JA expects the specified AI capabilities, such as business slogan generation and CEO speech transcription, to be built directly into the simulation software as embedded, task-specific tools. These features are designed to support discrete student activities (e.g., marketing or leadership exercises) rather than serve as open-ended AI experiences. Consistent with this approach, JA BizTown will not include a general-purpose chatbot.

We are prioritizing strong guardrails to ensure all AI interactions are appropriate for 5th–6th grade students. This includes limiting AI outputs to structured, a three strike system, context-specific prompts; avoiding open-ended or unsupervised interactions; and ensuring outputs are safe, relevant, and aligned with educational objectives. Additional considerations such as content moderation, privacy protections, and compliance with student data regulations will also be essential.

While the AI features outlined in the RFP represent the current required scope, JA is open to exploring additional AI-enabled capabilities in partnership with the selected vendor. Any such enhancements would need to clearly support the learning objectives, remain developmentally appropriate, and fit within the overall simulation experience.

Overall, JA views AI as a tool to enhance, not replace, the hands-on, collaborative nature of the JA BizTown experience, and we look forward to working with the vendor to implement these capabilities thoughtfully and responsibly.

4. Value-Driven Pricing and Phased Delivery Options

Given the breadth of the BizTown redevelopment—spanning a full-stack mobile application, CMS, three dashboard systems, paper-based fallback, AI features, gamification, accessibility compliance, and multi-site management for 100+ facilities—does JA have a preferred approach to phased delivery that prioritizes the highest-value capabilities for the January 2027 pilot while allowing lower-priority features to be delivered incrementally? Is JA open to a value-driven pricing model where cost is tied to delivered outcomes and milestone acceptance rather than purely time-and-materials?

JA Response: yes JA is open to different pricing models.

5. End-to-End Platform Ownership and Post-Launch Stewardship

The RFP mentions a continuing support arrangement with an annual upgrade/revision cycle. Can JA describe the envisioned post-launch operating model—specifically, who will own production monitoring and incident response (Tier 1/2/3 support), how enhancement requests will be prioritized and funded, and whether JA envisions the selected vendor serving as a long-term platform steward or transitioning to an internal team? What SLA expectations does JA have for system availability, especially during peak simulation periods?

JA Response: JA expects to create monitoring with the vendor. JA expects the vendor to own troubleshooting and training of JA USA Technical staff. When the product goes live, we expect that the alerts and monitors will let JA USA handle most incidents with escalations to vendor for some continuing period of time. We expect system availability to be 100% during peak times (M-F, 8 AM to 7 PM ET).

6. Multi-Site Architecture and National-to-Local Configuration Strategy

The CMS requirements describe a national master template with local site-level customization layers supporting 100+ facilities, version history, rollback, and the ability to push national updates without overwriting local changes. Can JA provide more detail on the current customization patterns across JA Areas—for example, how many distinct configuration variations exist today, how frequently local areas modify their setups, and what the most common customization conflicts are when national changes are pushed? Is there an expectation for the vendor to architect a configuration inheritance model, or should local and national configurations remain fully independent?

JA Response: JA Areas currently operate with a high degree of flexibility in how their JA BizTown simulations are configured. Local sites are able to customize nearly all aspects of their experience, including business types, job roles, and individual job tasks. In addition, Areas can adjust operational variables such as tax rates, student salaries, scheduling elements (e.g., break timing and structure), and other simulation parameters.

In practice, most JA Areas make updates to their configurations a few times per year, primarily during the summer and the next largest window being over holiday breaks in the winter. These changes are typically driven by factors such as onboarding new business sponsors, introducing or refining job roles and tasks, or correcting issues identified during program delivery. Areas are typically customizing 100-150 job roles within the simulation. While there is significant variation across sites today, we do not currently experience frequent conflicts related to national updates, largely because those updates have historically been limited.

As part of the redevelopment, however, JA's goal is to move toward a more standardized and consistent national experience, while still preserving the ability for local Areas to incorporate meaningful, but more controlled, customization. We anticipate a model where core elements of

the simulation are defined and maintained at the national level, with clearly designated layers for local configuration.

Accordingly, JA expects the selected vendor to architect a configuration model that supports this balance, most likely through a structured inheritance or layering approach. This would allow national updates to be deployed efficiently while preserving approved local customizations and minimizing conflicts. JA also expects local Area CMS to have the ability to be cloned and duplicated. Key capabilities such as version control, change tracking, and rollback will be important to ensure stability and transparency across both national and local levels.

Overall, the intent is to reduce unnecessary variability, improve scalability across locations, and enable a more streamlined process for maintaining and evolving the JA BizTown experience over time.

7. Real-Time Transaction Architecture and Network Resilience

The RFP emphasizes real-time transaction synchronization across student checking accounts, business accounts, financial institutions, and dashboards—all operating over facility WiFi that may be unreliable. Can JA clarify expectations for transaction consistency in degraded network conditions? Should the system support local-first or offline-capable operation with eventual synchronization, or is persistent connectivity assumed? Additionally, what are the performance benchmarks for transaction throughput during peak activity (e.g., shopping breaks with 150 students transacting simultaneously)?

JA Response: JA recognizes that reliable real-time transaction processing is critical to the JA BizTown simulation, particularly during high-activity periods, and that facility WiFi conditions may vary.

The system is expected to support offline-capable or “local-first” operation with eventual synchronization. Student devices should be able to continue key activities (e.g., purchases, deposits, payments) even in the event of temporary connectivity disruptions, with data syncing seamlessly once connectivity is restored. At the same time, JA is not expecting or requiring a traditional on-premise/local server solution; vendors should propose architectures that balance resilience with a cloud-based or hybrid approach.

From a consistency standpoint, the system should prioritize accuracy and reconciliation across all entities, including student checking accounts, business accounts, and financial institution dashboards, once synchronization occurs. The user experience should remain smooth and intuitive, with minimal visible disruption during transient network issues.

In terms of performance, JA expects the platform to handle peak activity levels efficiently. At a typical facility, there may be approximately 150 students participating, with around 30 students transacting simultaneously during shopping periods. Within a 10-minute window, this can result

in roughly 500 transaction events. The system should be designed to support on the order of 50–100 transactions per second during peak load without noticeable lag or degradation in user experience.

Overall, the expectation is a highly responsive, resilient system that maintains data integrity while accommodating real-world network variability across all JA locations.

8. Accessibility-First Design and Compliance Validation

The RFP requires WCAG 2.2 AA compliance, VPATs for each theme/section, visual/text/read-aloud modes, and no reliance on sound or fast reaction times. Can JA clarify whether these accessibility requirements extend equally to all interfaces (student app, CMS, staff/volunteer dashboards, teacher portal), and what testing methodology JA expects—autoated scanning, manual expert audit, user testing with individuals who have disabilities, or a combination? Does JA have an existing relationship with an accessibility auditor, or should the vendor include third-party auditing in the proposal?

JA Response: Accessibility requirements apply to all interfaces aside from the JA Area Staff (though we expect basic compliance for that group as well). JA has a relationship with an external auditor who support running a VPAT and those costs. We typically test with a combination of automated scanning, and manual expert audits.

9. Pilot Strategy, Feedback Integration, and Launch Readiness Criteria

The RFP indicates pilot testing with advisory JA Areas from January through March 2027, followed by updates and a June 2027 launch. Can JA define the specific launch readiness criteria that must be met before the system goes to production—including acceptable defect thresholds, performance benchmarks, minimum pilot participation, and stakeholder sign-off requirements? How does JA envision the feedback loop during pilot—will there be structured sprint cycles dedicated to pilot remediation, and what is the escalation path if pilot findings reveal scope that was not anticipated during Discovery?

JA Response: JA has defined a set of launch readiness criteria to ensure the JA BizTown platform is stable, performant, and aligned with user needs prior to full production release.

Launch Readiness Criteria

1. Functional Completeness & Accessibility

- **Pilot Phase:** Core end-to-end experiences are functional for primary audiences (students, volunteers, staff), with accessibility aligned to key WCAG considerations (e.g., color contrast, reflow/orientation).

- **Initial Release:** Fully functional experience for all user groups, with **strict WCAG compliance** across the platform.

2. Acceptable Defect Thresholds

- **Pilot Phase:** Acceptable defect levels will be collaboratively defined with the vendor but should reflect a realistic, usable experience for end users in a live simulation environment.
- **Initial Release:** No known critical or high-severity defects; only minor or cosmetic issues may remain, as approved by JA stakeholders.

3. Performance Benchmarks

- **Pilot Phase:**
  - Stable performance under typical simulation conditions (80–150 students, 14–20 businesses)
  - No major latency impacting core workflows (e.g., transactions, role-based activities, dashboard updates)
- **Initial Release:**
  - Consistent, low-latency performance during peak activity (e.g., shopping periods)
  - Ability to handle expected transaction volumes (as defined in prior requirements) without degradation
  - Reliable operation in environments with variable WiFi, including degraded-mode functionality

4. Minimum Pilot Participation
The pilot will include:

- 10–15 JA Areas
- 3–5 simulations per Area
- 14–20 businesses per simulation
- 80–150 students per simulation

This scale is intended to validate performance, usability, and operational readiness across a representative cross-section of locations.

5. Stakeholder Sign-Off
Formal sign-off will be required prior to launch and will include:

- JA USA product and program leadership
- Key functional stakeholders (e.g., UX, content, operations)
- Validation that the platform meets defined requirements established during Discovery and Design phases

Pilot Feedback Loop & Remediation Approach

JA envisions a structured and iterative feedback loop during the pilot phase, including:

- Regular feedback cycles with participating JA Areas to capture insights from students, volunteers, and staff
- Defined sprint cycles dedicated to pilot remediation, prioritizing critical fixes and high-impact improvements
- Use of a shared bug/issue tracking system (vendor-provided or mutually agreed upon) to document, prioritize, and resolve issues

To proactively reduce major scope changes, JA is engaging an advisory group of JA Areas throughout Discovery and Design to ensure alignment with end-user needs before pilot begins.

Scope Changes & Escalation Path

If pilot findings surface unanticipated needs or gaps:

- Issues will be triaged and categorized (e.g., defect vs. enhancement vs. scope change)
- Critical issues impacting core functionality or user experience will be prioritized for resolution prior to launch
- Non-critical enhancements may be deferred to post-launch phases, based on impact and timeline considerations
- Any material scope changes will follow a defined governance process, including stakeholder review, prioritization, and alignment on timeline and budget implications

10. Vendor In-Person Immersion and Stakeholder Engagement Model

The RFP mentions that the selected vendor should volunteer in-person at a JA BizTown simulation in May 2026 before project kickoff. Can JA describe the full stakeholder engagement model expected throughout the project—including how frequently in-person sessions will occur, which JA team members (product ownership, UX, content, evaluation, technical) will be available and at what commitment level, and whether JA expects the vendor's leadership team (not just delivery staff) to participate in key milestone reviews? This helps us plan our engagement architecture around JA's operating rhythm.

> **JA Response:** JA is committed to a highly collaborative and structured stakeholder engagement model throughout the JA BizTown redevelopment.
>
> The project will begin with an in-person kickoff in May 2026, which will also include the selected vendor participating in a live JA BizTown simulation experience. This is intended to provide critical context and alignment before development begins.

Throughout the project, JA expects:

- **Weekly Working Sessions:**
  A standing 2-hour weekly meeting focused on project updates, progress reviews, and key decision points. Core JA participants will include members of the project team such as Product Ownership, Project Management, UX/UI, and other relevant contributors as needed.
- **Vendor Leadership Engagement:**
  JA expects the vendor's leadership team, not just delivery staff, to be actively involved at key milestones. This includes participation in major reviews and strategic checkpoints, as well as a recurring 30-minute leadership sync following the weekly working session to ensure alignment, escalation management, and decision-making continuity.
- **Pre-Read Expectations:**
  To ensure productive discussions, JA requests that all materials requiring review (e.g., designs, deliverables, decisions) be shared at least 24 hours in advance of scheduled meetings. This allows the JA team to come prepared with feedback and approvals.
- **In-Person Engagements:**
  While the majority of collaboration will occur virtually, JA anticipates select in-person sessions at key phases (e.g., kickoff, major milestone reviews, pilot readiness), as mutually agreed upon.
- **Roles and Availability:**
  JA will provide consistent access to key stakeholders across product, UX, content, evaluation, and technical perspectives, with engagement levels scaled based on project phase and needs.
- **Vendor Responsibilities:**
  The vendor will be expected to lead overall project orchestration, including maintaining the meeting cadence, setting agendas, documenting outcomes, and managing stakeholder sign-offs and approvals.

Overall, JA is looking for a proactive, well-organized partnership with clear communication, strong leadership alignment, and a shared commitment to delivering a high-quality product.

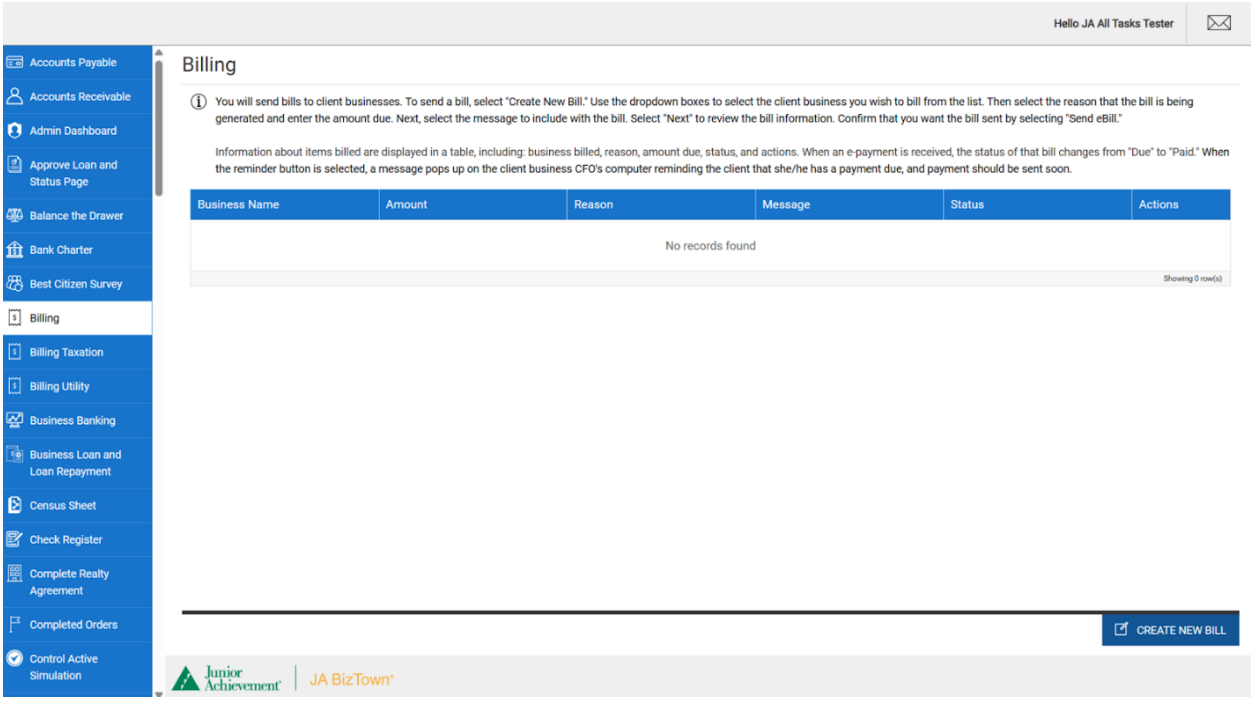
11. **What are the current BizTown pain points you are trying to solve for in this new version?**

JA response: JA's primary motivation for redeveloping the JA BizTown simulation is to modernize both the experience and the technology so that it better reflects today's, and tomorrow's, world of work.

One of the most significant pain points is that the current simulation model is outdated and no longer aligned with how modern businesses operate. For example, elements such as a

traditional newspaper business do not reflect the digital-first media landscape students are familiar with. We want the simulation to incorporate more relevant, forward-looking concepts such as digital marketing, modern communication channels, and contemporary business operations.

Current JA BizTown Simulation Software (Billing):



Another key challenge is the current user interface, which is heavily text-based and not optimized for how 5th and 6th grade students learn and engage. The experience does not fully leverage interactive, visual, or intuitive design principles that support engagement and comprehension for this age group. As a result, there is an opportunity to significantly improve usability, accessibility, and overall student engagement.

Additionally, the existing platform lacks the flexibility and scalability needed to support a consistent, high-quality experience across JA locations nationwide, while still allowing for meaningful local customization. Operationally, this can create inefficiencies for staff and inconsistencies in program delivery.

> In the new version, JA is seeking a solution that blends real-world relevance (e.g., point-of-sale systems, digital financial tools, and modern business practices) with an engaging, age-appropriate user experience. The goal is to create a simulation that is intuitive, immersive, and aligned with both educational best practices and the evolving workforce landscape.

12. **How should the real-time transaction engine handle conflicts and failures?**

With 150 students transacting simultaneously across an interconnected economy, what happens when: a student tries to buy something but the business account is frozen? A payroll submission happens while a purchase is deducting from the same business account? The network drops mid-transaction? What are the acceptable latency thresholds for cross-system updates?

JA response: JA would expect that the system will gracefully handle contention between transactions. We would expect latency thresholds to be in the low seconds (1-2).

13. **What is the scope of the "Canva-like" digital marketing tool?**

Building a design tool with template editing, text/image manipulation, and cross-device sharing is a significant engineering effort on its own. What are the minimum viable features? Is this drag-and-drop with templates, or do students need to create from scratch? What asset library is provided? How sophisticated does cross-device sharing need to be (real-time collaboration vs. export-and-share)?

JA response: JA envisions the “Canva-like” digital marketing tool as a guided, age-appropriate design experience rather than a fully open-ended or professional-grade design platform. The focus is on enabling students to successfully create a simple, effective advertisement within the context of the simulation.

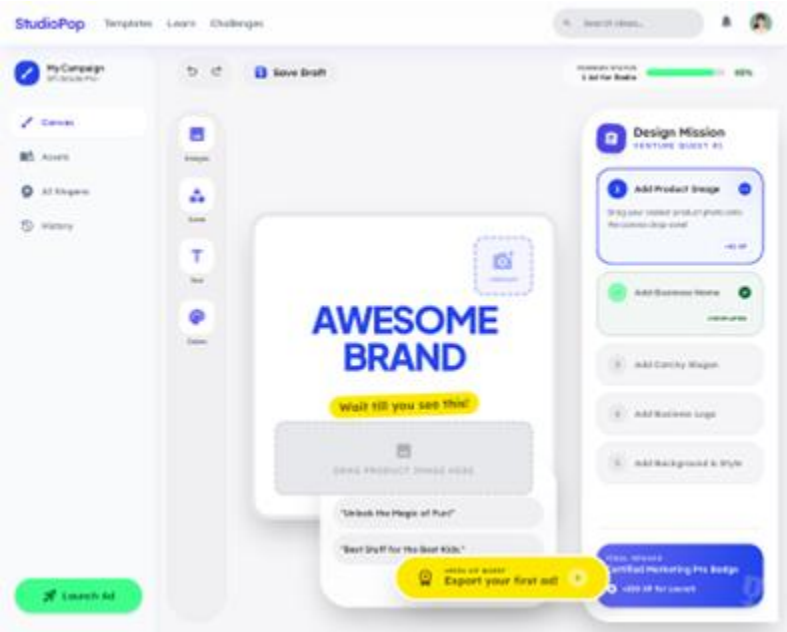
The minimum viable features for this tool include:
• A structured, step-by-step “design mission” that guides students through the creation process and ensures their advertisement includes key elements (e.g., business name, slogan, visual, and clear message).
• A template-based design approach, where students select from pre-built layouts rather than creating designs from scratch.
• The ability to add and edit text, including at minimum their business name and AI-generated or student-created slogan.
• The ability to select or change background images or simple design elements.
• Access to a curated asset library of images, with the ability for JA Area administrators to upload and manage assets via the CMS.

From a functionality standpoint, the tool should prioritize ease of use, clarity, and speed over advanced design capabilities such as complex layering, precision editing, or fully freeform drag-and-drop systems.

Regarding sharing, JA's primary requirement is that students can easily publish or display their final advertisement within the simulation so it can be viewed by other participants (e.g., displayed digitally throughout the town experience). We are flexible on the technical approach to achieve this and do not require real-time collaboration. A simple and reliable publish or export-and-display workflow is sufficient for the MVP.

Overall, the goal is to provide a lightweight, intuitive tool that supports learning objectives and creativity without introducing unnecessary complexity.

Example design:



14. **How does the screen sharing feature work technically?**

    When the CFO does a loan application visible to all team members: is this a real-time screen mirror (like a cast)? Or a shared state view where all devices show the same app state? Does this need to work over the facility's potentially spotty WiFi? How many simultaneous screen-share sessions (one per business = 14–20)?

JA response: JA envisions this feature as a real-time screen-sharing experience, where the CFO's device is effectively mirrored to other team members so they can observe the loan application process as it is being completed.

This capability should support multiple concurrent sessions, with the expectation that each business within the simulation (approximately 14–20 per facility) may be running its own screen-sharing session simultaneously.

The feature must function reliably within a typical facility WiFi environment. While JA will work to ensure adequate network infrastructure, the solution should be designed with resilience in mind, accounting for potential variability in connectivity and bandwidth. Vendors are encouraged to consider approaches that optimize performance under these conditions (e.g., efficient streaming, low-latency updates, or alternative architectures that achieve a similar real-time shared experience).

From a user perspective, the experience should be seamless and require minimal setup or intervention from students or staff.

While JA has described this as a screen-mirroring experience, we are open to alternative technical approaches, such as shared state views, if they can deliver the same real-time visibility, reliability, and ease of use within the simulation environment.

15. **What offline/degraded-network capabilities are expected?**

The JAFP Q&A revealed facility WiFi can be spotty with 200 concurrent users. BizTown's real-time transaction requirements are much heavier. Should the app queue transactions locally and sync when connectivity returns? What's the fallback if real-time sync isn't possible? Is the paper-based version the only offline fallback, or do you want a degraded-but-functional digital mode?

JA's response: JA does not view JA BizTown's transaction requirements as materially heavier than those of JA Finance Park; however, we recognize that network variability is a real consideration across facilities.

JA expects the platform to support a degraded-but-functional digital mode rather than relying on a full reversion to paper-based operations. In situations where connectivity is limited or temporarily unavailable, the system should allow core activities, such as transactions, to continue with minimal disruption to the student experience.

16. **Are Phases 8 and 12 (Business Scenarios) optional for MVP?**

In the JAFP Q&A, vendors asked if optional phases could be deferred. The business scenario system (ethical dilemmas, XP consequences, CMS-configurable donation amounts) is a substantial feature. Can this be post-launch?

JA response: Because the Business Scenarios phase encompasses “character education” that is required for the grant that is funding this project, this is a feature that should be included for the initial pilot launch.

17. **What is the radio/music integration requirement exactly?**

The RFP mentions "music/radio software integrated into the software with the ability to connect to the facility's A/V system." Does this mean: (a) a music player UI in the app that outputs to speakers via Bluetooth/AirPlay? (b) A streaming interface? (c) Just a list of slogans that can be read aloud? What about music licensing? Is there an existing A/V setup at facilities?

JA response: JA’s goal for the radio/music integration is to provide a streamlined, centralized solution that replaces the fragmented approaches currently used across JA Areas.

Today, many facilities include a “radio station” storefront where music is played throughout the space; however, there is no standardized or integrated system to support this, creating operational challenges. The redevelopment aims to solve this by embedding a simple, reliable audio management capability directly within the simulation software.

At a minimum, JA envisions:

- A built-in “DJ Dashboard” within the application that allows a student DJ to:
    - Select and play music from a predefined, curated playlist
    - Start/stop and switch tracks easily during the simulation
- Audio output that integrates with the facility’s existing A/V system (e.g., via a central machine connected to speakers)
- Microphone integration that allows the student DJ to make live announcements (e.g., reading business slogans or messages) over the same speaker system

JA is flexible on the exact technical implementation (e.g., local playback vs. streaming interface), as long as the experience is seamless and reliable for end users. Most facilities already have some form of A/V infrastructure in place, though configurations may vary, so the solution should be adaptable to different setups.

From a scope perspective, this is not intended to be a full-featured music streaming platform. The expectation is a controlled environment with a predefined set of audio tracks. Considerations such as music licensing will need to be addressed, and JA is open to vendor guidance on best practices or recommended approaches in this area.

Overall, the priority is ease of use, consistency across locations, and a more engaging, realistic radio experience within the JA BizTown simulation.

18. **Is the design style still 2.5D isometric low poly, or should BizTown have a different look?**

The JAFP Q&A confirmed 2.5D isometric low poly for Finance Park. BizTown targets a younger audience (ages 9–12 vs 12–18). Should the visual style be different? More playful? The RFP mentions "modern, age-appropriate interface aligned with today's financial applications" — which suggests more realistic than gamified.

JA response: JA will provide input on design style that is grade-appropriate, in-line with our Experiential Learning Centers (JA BizTown, JA Finance Park, and more), and align with our brand. We expect mood boards or style tiles to together align on approach to color, font, illustration style, photo style as needed. We do not anticipate a 3D world. Artwork will either be 2.5D or isometric, TBD.

19. **What NFC hardware is available at facilities?**

The RFP says to "explore ability to use NFC as payment." Do facilities have NFC readers? Are the tablets NFC-capable? Is this a nice-to-have or a requirement? What about device compatibility across iOS and Android NFC capabilities?

JA response: JA anticipates that facilities will be equipped with a mix of iOS and Android tablets, many of which will have built-in NFC capabilities. Additionally, some locations may choose to procure simple external NFC readers that can connect to tablets or computers, depending on their specific setup.

At this time, NFC functionality is considered a **nice-to-have enhancement rather than a core requirement** for the JA BizTown simulation. Vendors are encouraged to explore its feasibility and potential value within the experience, but it is not required for the MVP.

Given the variability in device types and configurations across JA locations, any proposed NFC solution should account for cross-platform compatibility (iOS and Android) and differing hardware capabilities. Flexibility and graceful degradation (e.g., alternative payment methods) will be important to ensure a consistent experience across all sites.

20. **What are the AI feature requirements in detail?**

Two AI features are mentioned: (1) sales strategy slogans and (2) CEO speech transcription. For #1: is this a text generation API call, or a more interactive experience? For #2: is this speech-to-text transcription, or AI-assisted speech writing? Will JA provide the AI service (as they did for JAFP's chatbot), or is this vendor scope?

JA response: JA's approach to AI within the JA BizTown simulation is intentionally targeted, age-appropriate, and closely aligned to the program's educational goals.

At a high level, JA expects the specified AI capabilities to be built and integrated by the vendor as part of the simulation software. These are not intended to be open-ended AI experiences, but rather embedded, task-specific tools that support defined student activities.

1. Sales Strategy / Slogan Generation
This feature is envisioned as a guided text generation experience, not a fully open prompt-based interface. Students may input a small amount of structured information (e.g., business type, target audience, product), and the system will generate a limited set of slogan options for selection or light iteration. The experience should be:

- Highly scaffolded and easy to use for 5th–6th grade students
- Constrained in output (e.g., a few options vs. unlimited regeneration)
- Aligned to the educational objective of understanding marketing fundamentals

2. CEO Speech Feature
This is intended to be speech-to-text transcription, not AI-generated speech writing. The goal is for students to deliver a short speech (e.g., to their business or the broader town), which is then transcribed and potentially displayed within the simulation. The emphasis is on:

- Supporting student expression and presentation skills
- Providing a record or display of what was said
- Not generating or replacing the student's original content

AI Guardrails and Student Safety
JA places a strong emphasis on guardrails to ensure all AI interactions are appropriate for 5th–6th grade users. Expectations include:

- Structured, context-specific inputs and outputs (no open-ended chat experiences)
- A "three-attempt" or similarly limited retry system to prevent misuse
- Content moderation and filtering to ensure safe, relevant outputs
- Compliance with student data privacy and protection standards

JA BizTown will not include a general-purpose chatbot.

AI Ownership and Flexibility
Unlike prior initiatives, JA is not prescribing a specific AI service for vendor use at this time. Vendors may propose appropriate AI approaches or integrations as part of their solution, provided they meet JA's requirements for safety, reliability, and educational alignment.

While the features outlined above represent the required MVP scope, JA is open to exploring additional AI-enabled capabilities in partnership with the selected vendor. Any enhancements must clearly support learning outcomes, remain developmentally appropriate, and fit within the structured nature of the simulation.

Overall, JA views AI as a tool to enhance, not replace, the hands-on, collaborative JA BizTown experience, and expects thoughtful, responsible implementation from the selected vendor.

21. **Is Node.js still acceptable as a backend alternative?**
    JA accepted Node.js for JAFP. Does this carry over to JABT? If we're building on the same stack as Finance Park, this may already be decided.

JA response: Yes node.js is an acceptable option moving forward.

22. **How differentiated should the role-based UIs be?**
    The evaluation criteria mention CEOs in suits, creative CMOs, math-focused CFOs. How far should role differentiation go? Different color schemes per role? Different dashboard layouts? Different feature access? Or just different task lists with the same UI shell?

JA response: Visually they do not necessarily need to be differentiated, however they will be by overall UI (for example one has a POS system with its own navigation, another has a Payroll system). We will want to have a custom graphic that can be added in a CMS for each storefront/business to give a more realistic experience for students.

23. **What does "shared device" mean in context?**
    The gamification section mentions "shared-device environments" and "be usable on shared devices." Does this mean a single device is shared between multiple students (rotating), or that the business dashboard is displayed on a shared screen? This significantly impacts session management and authentication design.

JA response: Please disregard “shared device”. It has been determined that a one device per user model will be utilized going forward.

24. **Should the volunteer dashboard show when and why to intervene automatically?**
    The RFP says "the platform must clearly define when and why a volunteer should intervene, minimizing ambiguity." Does this mean: automated alerts when a business is struggling? A rules engine that flags specific situations? Or just a static guide with decision trees?

JA response: JA’s primary goal for the volunteer dashboard is to provide clear, real-time visibility into what each business is doing, rather than prescribing exactly when or why a volunteer should intervene.

The intent is for volunteers to be able to quickly understand business performance, student activity, and potential issues through intuitive visual indicators or summaries. This visibility should enable volunteers to use their own judgment to support students as needed.

To clarify, JA does not require:

- Automated alerts that dictate when intervention must occur
- A rules engine that flags or enforces specific intervention scenarios
- Prescriptive workflows or decision trees for volunteer actions

Instead, the focus is on:

- Transparency into business operations and progress
- Simple, easy-to-interpret dashboards
- Empowering volunteers with information, not instructions

Based on this clarification, the referenced language in the RFP regarding explicitly defining when and why volunteers should intervene can be considered non-essential and may be removed.

25. **Is this a fixed-bid project like JAFP?**
    The JAFP Q&A referenced this as a "fixed-bid project." Given BizTown's significantly larger scope and many features marked as TBD for discovery, is this still fixed-bid? How will scope changes during discovery be handled? This project is more dynamic than JAFP.

JA response: JA is open to different pricing models but this project also has fixed funding. The work should not exceed 1M for initial release.

26. **What is the budget range or constraint?**
    JA declined to share budget for JAFP. BizTown has substantially more complexity. Any budget guidance would help right-size the proposal — especially for features like the digital marketing tool, radio integration, and screen sharing that could range from simple to very complex implementations.

JA response: see response above.

27. **What does the in-person volunteer experience look like logistically?**
    The milestone table shows "Vendor Volunteers In-Person for a JA BizTown Simulation" in May 2026. Is this a prerequisite before project kickoff or concurrent?

JA response: The goal for the in-person volunteer experience would be that the volunteering happens concurrent with the in-person kick off meeting. This circumstance will depend on the

location of the vendor selected and the proximity of a JA Area with a JA BizTown space to the location where the in-person kickoff will be held.

28. **Is the June 2027 timeline realistic given scope?**
    BizTown has significantly more complexity than Finance Park (POS, banking, payroll, billing, marketing tool, voting, radio, screen sharing, business scenarios, team building) but has the same general timeframe. Is there flexibility in the timeline, or are certain modules acceptable for post-launch? We anticipate the proposed timeline being tight.

JA response: While the overall project timeline is intentionally aggressive, it is critical that the initial release delivers the agreed-upon core scope and foundational capabilities. JA recognizes the need to balance speed with quality and will work closely with the selected vendor to clearly define priorities, confirm requirements, and align on delivery expectations for the initial release. Through regular check-ins and collaborative planning, JA and the vendor will ensure scope decisions are transparent, achievable within the timeline, and positioned to support future enhancements without compromising the success of the first launch.

29. **Are data privacy regulations resolved yet?**
    For JAFP, JA said they were "still determining" FERPA/COPPA and state-specific regulations. A year later for JABT, has this been resolved? This is especially important for BizTown since the audience is younger (ages 9–12), which may trigger additional COPPA requirements.

JA response: This should not be an issue as we will not be asking students for email addresses or any other personal identifying information.

30. **How does the "customizable free space" for local tasks work?**
    The module list includes a customizable free space for JA Areas to add unique tasks" with guidelines (character limit, design, etc.). What types of tasks are envisioned? Is this a simple text/instruction display, or does it need interactive elements? How much creative freedom do local areas expect?

JA response: JA envisions the “customizable free space” as a lightweight, structured way for local JA Areas to incorporate location-specific tasks into the simulation, primarily tied to their unique business sponsors and job roles.

An example of a task would be: *“Visit each business in the town and share your company’s service offering with the CEO.”* These tasks are intended to reinforce real-world behaviors such as communication, sales, and collaboration, and would typically occur during the Business Operations phase of the simulation.

From a functionality standpoint, this feature is expected to be simple and non-interactive. Specifically:

- Tasks will be presented as text-based instructions, with the option to include supporting images
- No complex interactivity (e.g., form inputs, branching logic, or system-driven validation) is required
- The experience should be easy for JA Area staff to configure and for students to understand quickly

In terms of flexibility, JA does want to enable local customization, but within clearly defined guardrails to maintain a consistent national experience. These include:

- Character limits to prevent overly long or complex instructions
- Predefined templates or standardized layouts to ensure visual consistency
- Basic formatting controls rather than full design freedom

Overall, the goal is to strike a balance between local relevance and national consistency, allowing Areas to add meaningful, context-specific content without introducing complexity or design variability into the student experience.

31. **Simulation & Experience Design**

How standardized is the BizTown simulation across JA Areas? Are businesses, roles, and workflows consistent nationally, or configurable per site?

JA response: Across JA Areas, most JA BizTown schedules and flows look similar, but all businesses, job roles, and tasks are unique to that JA Area because they reflect the local economy and sponsors.

32. **What are the non-negotiable learning outcomes the platform must preserve?**

JA response: From a student impact perspective, our primary goal is for participants to leave their JA BizTown experience with a deeper understanding of teamwork, how businesses operate, and the value of every role within an organization. We aim to see measurable growth in financial literacy at both the personal and business levels, as well as increased confidence in applying those concepts in real-world scenarios. Additionally, we prioritize outcomes related to character development, including ethical decision-making, responsibility, and effective collaboration. These outcomes may be assessed through a combination of pre- and post-experience evaluations, educator feedback, and student self-reflection.

33. **Are there multiple simulation variants today that we should account for?**

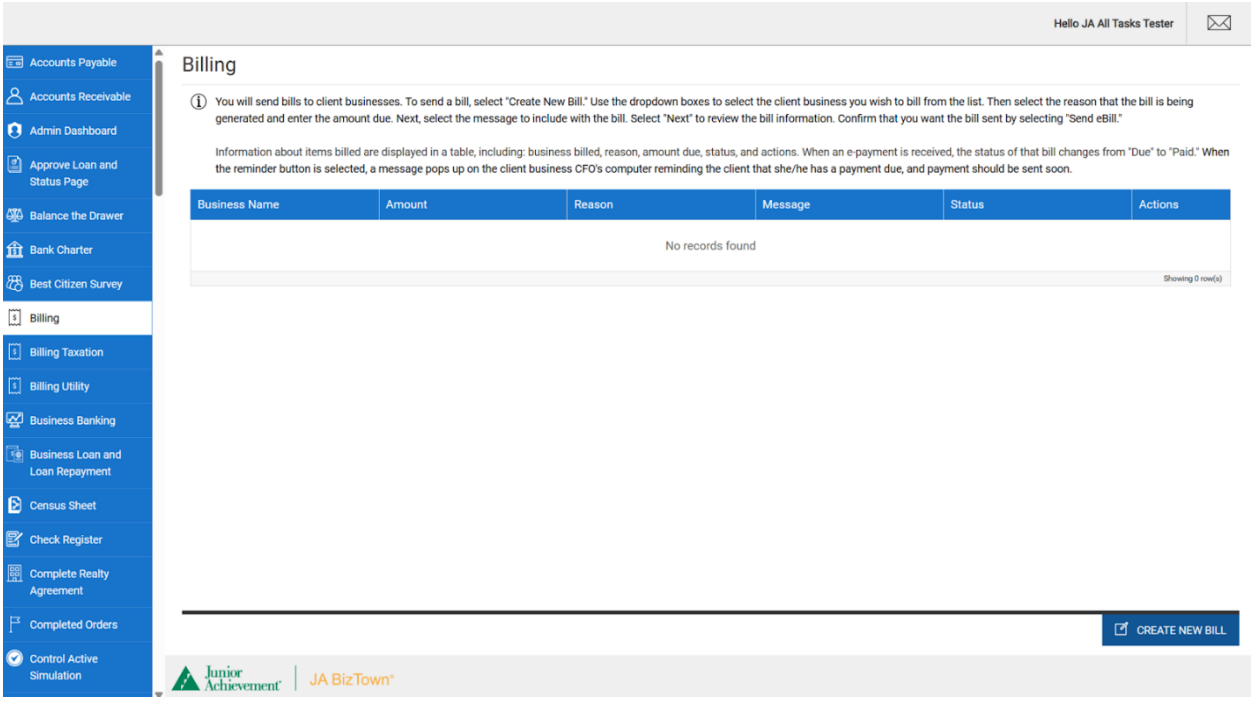
JA response: The main variance between local Area simulations is the difference in the roles and businesses. Otherwise, the schedule and flows of the day look similar.

34. **What are the primary pain points in the current BizTown experience (digital and physical)?**

JA response: JA's primary motivation for redeveloping the JA BizTown simulation is to modernize both the experience and the technology so that it better reflects today's, and tomorrow's, world of work.

One of the most significant pain points is that the current simulation model is outdated and no longer aligned with how modern businesses operate. For example, elements such as a traditional newspaper business do not reflect the digital-first media landscape students are familiar with. We want the simulation to incorporate more relevant, forward-looking concepts such as digital marketing, modern communication channels, and contemporary business operations.

Current JA BizTown Simulation Software (Billing):



Another key challenge is the current user interface, which is heavily text-based and not optimized for how 5th and 6th grade students learn and engage. The experience does not fully leverage interactive, visual, or intuitive design principles that support engagement and comprehension for this age group. As a result, there is an opportunity to significantly improve usability, accessibility, and overall student engagement.

Additionally, the existing platform lacks the flexibility and scalability needed to support a consistent, high-quality experience across JA locations nationwide, while still allowing for meaningful local customization. Operationally, this can create inefficiencies for staff and inconsistencies in program delivery.

In the new version, JA is seeking a solution that blends real-world relevance (e.g., point-of-sale systems, digital financial tools, and modern business practices) with an engaging, age-appropriate user experience. The goal is to create a simulation that is intuitive, immersive, and aligned with both educational best practices and the evolving workforce landscape.

35. **Are there any existing user research insights or evaluations we can leverage?**

JA response: Yes, we have some existing evaluations from JA BizTown as well as summaries and findings from recent strategy and discovery sessions with JA Areas.

36. **How do you envision team-building exercises being supported within the platform?**

JA response: The main goals of the team building exercise are:

- Allow for an opportunity for the students to learn more about the business they are working in.
- Create time for the students in the business to get to know each other and start the day with working as a team.
- Instill the idea that all roles in the team are important and required for the smooth running of the business.

JA is flexible with the means to this end. The platform could simply provide instructions for the team-building exercise that the students are doing in more of a hands-on way, or the team building exercise could be fully built into the software.

37. **User Roles & Experience Model** Can you provide a high-level view of user roles (students, teachers, volunteers, simulation managers, admins) and their responsibilities?

JA response:

Simulation Managers:

▪ Typically, full-time JA Area staff

▪ Responsible for -

●Customizing/localizing CMS

●Creating simulation templates

●Setting up and activating simulations

●Leading day-of volunteer training

●Leading day-of simulation experience with students, volunteers, teachers, and staff

●All physical and digital assets in JA BizTown

Volunteers:

▪ Volunteer types

●Corporate - volunteering as part of their organization

●Parent - parents of students attending JA BizTown

●Community - volunteering as part of local community groups (chambers, leadership groups, colleges, etc.)

▪ Volunteer roles

●Mentors and guides students through their JA BizTown day by providing them guidance on their job tasks, answering their questions about what it means to have a job, and adding in their own personal experience to enhance the learning Opportunities.

Educators:

○ May also be impromptu volunteers

○ Deliver 12 lessons of curriculum prior to the on-site simulation experience

○ Check for understanding with students throughout day and aligning JA BizTown visit to curriculum

○ Monitor student behavior and engagement

Students:

○ Elementary and Middle School - 5th through 6th grade

○ Participate in onsite 4hrs simulation where they are led by a JA Staff member on the microphone providing instructions, consult with their volunteers for guidance, and use what they've learned in the curriculum and recommendations within the software and from their volunteer to make wise financial decisions. Students make all decisions to run a successful business including applying for a loan, submitting payroll, voting, and making purchasing decisions.

38. **Should each role have a distinct interface, or a shared interface with role-based variations?**

JA response: Visually they do not necessarily need to be differentiated, however they will be by overall UI (for example one has a POS system with its own navigation, another has a Payroll system). We will want to have a custom graphic that can be added in a CMS for each storefront/business to give a more realistic experience for students.

39. **To what extent should experiences (especially dashboards and workflows) be customized per role?**

JA response: see above response

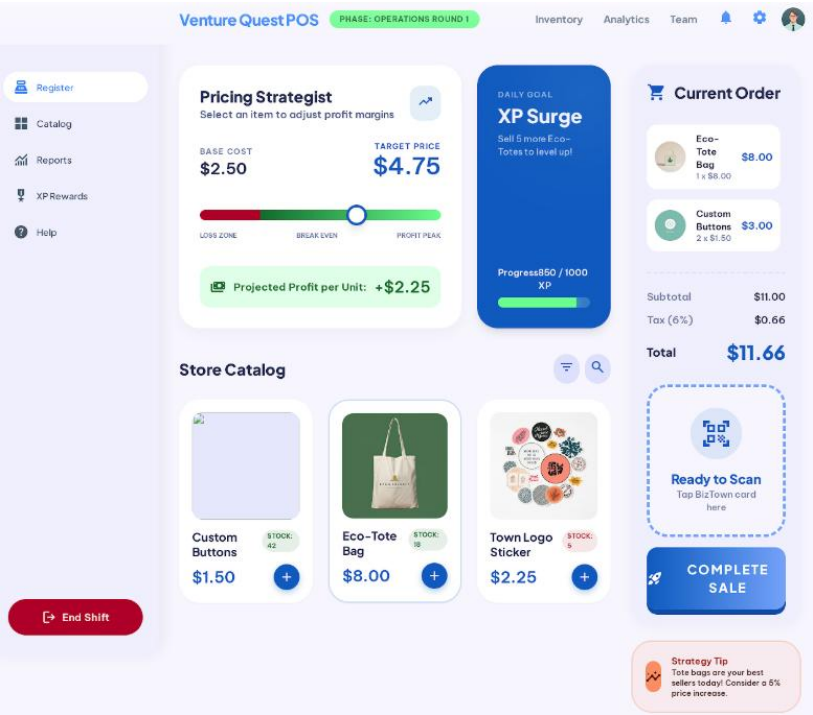
40. **Are there established guidelines for designing for ages 9–12 (reading level, interaction complexity, attention span)?**

JA response: Reading level is expected to be two grades lower than the target audience, so 3rd grade reading level is our expectation. The text in the simulation should be short and concise; no long paragraphs of text.

The design should be simple, have a clear hierarchy and information design in addition to obvious buttons and behavior which uses principles of proximity and persistence.

41. Should the experience prioritize simplicity and clarity, or real-world business accuracy, where trade-offs exist?

JA response: The experience should be a simple and clear version of real-world business experiences. For example, this is a sample design of what the POS system could look like:



This image shows features that can be included in a real-world POS system, including the store catalog, current order, and pricing. This information is presented in a simple and clear way that is easy to understand for 5th and 6th grade students.

42. **What level of onboarding is expected:**

o guided step-by-step flows,

o contextual help,

o or facilitator-led instruction?

JA response: The system shouldn't require extensive onboarding to be understood by students and volunteers. Some tasks such as sending pills, completing payroll, and setting up the POS system can include step-by-step flows/tips as the student is completing them for the first time. All tasks, though, should be intuitive to a 5th and 6th grade learner and should not require intensive instruction from the system, a volunteer, or a staff member.

Additionally, a JA Admin Staff training manual is expected. This manual should provide in depth information on all administrative functions in the simulation and in the CMS (CMS User Guide) as well as in depth information on all functions in the simulation itself (Simulation User Guide). All manuals should be geared towards JA Area staff

43. **How should the system handle errors (e.g., failed transactions):**

o visible and educational for students, or managed behind the scenes?

JA response: If a transaction does not go through for a certain reason (ie. student does not have enough funds in their account, business does not have enough funds in their account, etc.), the reason for the failed transaction should be explained to the student via a pop-up. We want students to be aware of why a transaction failed and be able to provide tips and solutions to complete a successful transaction next time.

44. **Can you share more about the physical simulation environment:**

o device usage (shared vs individual),

o student movement,

o environmental factors (noise, transitions)?

JA response: The physical JA BizTown simulation space varies Area to Area, but typically, the simulation space is:

- Comprised of 14-20 business storefronts
- A main “city center” area where students gather
- About 8-10k square feet

Within this space, currently, there are 2-3 devices per business. In the current model, not every student needs a device. Some students are able to complete their job roles from simple checklists on clipboards. Throughout the day, students are moving throughout the space to complete their job tasks, make purchasing decisions at other businesses, going to the bank, vote, etc. During the day, music is playing, announcements are being made over the A/V system by the JA staff, students are working together in their businesses and talking with each other and their volunteers.

45. **For the Radio, what are the standardized hardware specifications for the facility's A/V systems across the ~98 local JA Areas, or will the software need to accommodate a wide variety of legacy local audio systems?**

JA response: There is not a standardized hardware specification for facility’s A/V systems. Systems range from a simple bluetooth speaker with accompanying microphone and iPad to built in speakers throughout the space connected to radio station-style equipment. Therefore, the software will need to accommodate a wide variety of audio systems.

46. **To meet the WCAG 2.2 AA requirement, does JA USA require a third-party accessibility audit to certify compliance, or is a vendor self-authored VPAT sufficient?**

We require a third party audit and have a third party vendor we will provide.

47. **Will JA USA provide a complete digital asset library (logos, UI icons, sponsor graphics) at kickoff, or should we include comprehensive UX/UI visual asset creation in our design budget?**

JA response: JA will provide a JA BizTown product logo.

JA Local areas will need the ability to upload local sponsor logos in the CMS to appear in the appropriate locations on the UI.

Design vendor will provide UX/UI style guide based on design decisions in our design process. All original design assets created by the vendor will be provided to JAUSA in original formats.

48. **Are dashboards intended to support real-time decision-making during simulations, or primarily as post-action summaries?**

JA response: Dashboards should provide real-time accurate insight into the business success so that students, volunteers, and admin are able to make real-time decisions and actions throughout the day.

Additionally, the dashboards should provide post-simulation reports for (1) the students in the business to reflect on their day and (2) for the educators to review and see the success of their students post-simulation.

49. **What level of visualization is expected (simple metrics vs interactive analytics)?**

JA response: JA expects to see more interactive visualization that tell a story graphically around the transactions and actions that are occurring in the business. These transactions include, but aren't limited to:

- Business XPs
- Transactions coming in and going out of the business (sales, billing, loan payoff, etc.)
- Settings sales price (to pay back loan)

- Business finances and financial health

50. **Are there reference examples or benchmarks for the desired level of dashboard sophistication?**

In the new version, JA is seeking a solution that blends real-world relevance (e.g., point-of-sale systems, digital financial tools, and modern business practices) with an engaging, age-appropriate user experience. The goal is to create a simulation that is intuitive, immersive, and aligned with both educational best practices and the evolving workforce landscape.

51. **Regarding the leaderboard system, will JA USA provide the exact mathematical formula and balancing logic for Experience Points (XPs), or is the vendor expected to design and balance this virtual economy?**

JA response: JA will provide the actions that will cause a business or individual to gain or lose XPs and would like to work together with the vendor to determine what the exact logic and formula should look like based on the software.

52. **The RFP outlines a comprehensive long-term vision for the platform. To align our approach with your rollout plan, can you clarify how you envision phasing the capabilities across pilot and subsequent releases?**

    - For the Jan–Mar 2027 pilot, which capabilities are expected to be fully production-ready?

JA Response: JA expects to have a version that can effectively be tested based upon defined scope.

    - Are there areas you anticipate delivering in a simplified form for pilot and expanding post-pilot?

JA Response: pilot is intended to validate assumptions, reduce implementation risk, and inform scalable decision-making prior to full deployment.

- If we were to prioritize a lean but high-impact pilot, which areas would you consider most critical:
    - core student simulation experience
    - operational dashboards
    - CMS/configuration flexibility
- Are there specific areas you already anticipate phasing post-pilot?
- For the pilot, should we assume full simulation fidelity across all businesses, or a simplified subset of workflows?

- The "Scope of Work" section provides a brief, high-level summary of deliverables required to launch (Front-end simulation, CMS, Paper-based solution, and Dashboards) . However, the "Simulation Requirements" and "Technical Requirements" sections detail extensive, complex functionalities—such as AI integrations, A/V connectivity, digital marketing tools, and gamification leaderboards. Can you confirm if the brief list under "Scope of Work" represents a phased Minimum Viable Product (MVP) for the pilot/initial release, or is the vendor strictly expected to deliver every granular feature detailed throughout the entire RFP by the June 2027 launch?

JA Response: We will work closely with the chosen vendor to determine MVP for pilot and phasing of delivery against the initial release. As noted above pilot is critical to the success of this project so JA is committed to working closely with the chosen vendor to ensure success.

52. For AI capabilities (e.g., slogan generation, speech transcription): Will JA provide an AI tenant (e.g., Azure OpenAI), or should the vendor include provider selection and costs?

JA response: The vendor should provide selection and costs to build the structured AI features into the software.

53. For the digital marketing tool:

- Should we assume a template-driven experience with limited customization, or is there an expectation of more advanced editing capabilities, such as Canva?

JA response: JA envisions the “Canva-like” digital marketing tool as a guided, age-appropriate design experience rather than a fully open-ended or professional-grade design platform. The focus is on enabling students to successfully create a simple, effective advertisement within the context of the simulation.

The minimum viable features for this tool include:

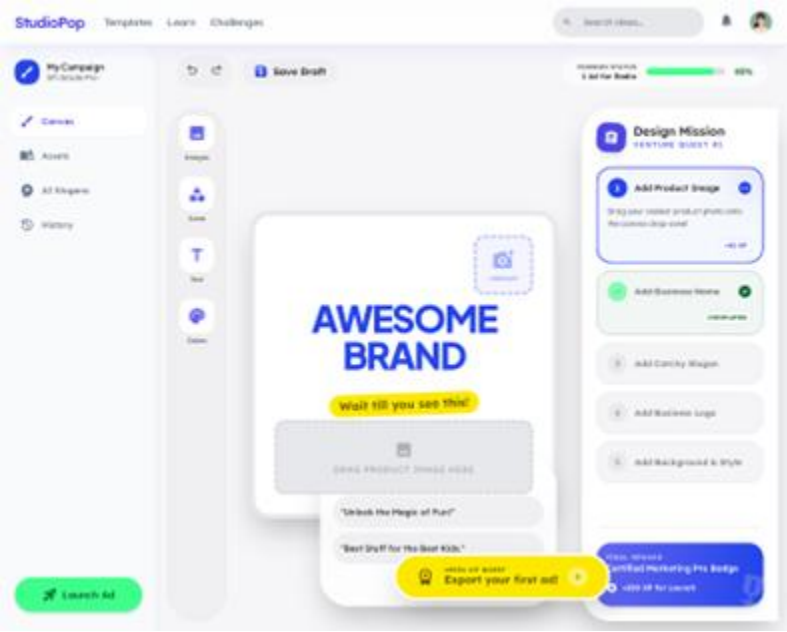
- A structured, step-by-step “design mission” that guides students through the creation process and ensures their advertisement includes key elements (e.g., business name, slogan, visual, and clear message).
- A template-based design approach, where students select from pre-built layouts rather than creating designs from scratch.
- The ability to add and edit text, including at minimum their business name and AI-generated or student-created slogan.
- The ability to select or change background images or simple design elements.
- Access to a curated asset library of images, with the ability for JA Area administrators to upload and manage assets via the CMS.

From a functionality standpoint, the tool should prioritize ease of use, clarity, and speed over advanced design capabilities such as complex layering, precision editing, or fully freeform drag-and-drop systems.

Regarding sharing, JA's primary requirement is that students can easily publish or display their final advertisement within the simulation so it can be viewed by other participants (e.g., displayed digitally throughout the town experience). We are flexible on the technical approach to achieve this and do not require real-time collaboration. A simple and reliable publish or export-and-display workflow is sufficient for the MVP.

Overall, the goal is to provide a lightweight, intuitive tool that supports learning objectives and creativity without introducing unnecessary complexity.

Example design:



54. For cross-device collaboration (e.g., CFO screen sharing):

- Should this be real-time mirroring or synchronized data views?

JA response: This should be real-time mirroring, but JA is flexible to the means to get to this end.

55. For payments:

- Should we assume specific hardware integrations, or device-native approaches (QR/NFC) for the pilot?

JA response: It should be assumed that there will be various hardware integrations across Areas for the pilot. The device-native approaches (NFC), are a “nice to have” feature and not required for the MVP.

56. For POS:

- Is the system expected to support physical peripherals (printers/drawers), or remain fully digital?

JA response: The POS system is not expected to support physical peripherals. The system will be fully digital with the addition of hardware to either use a tap-to-pay device and/or a debit card reader.

57. On Azure:

- Should the vendor define the architecture, or deploy into a pre-configured environment?

JA’s response: JA will work with the vendor to deploy the architecture and get it deployed into JA’s environment.

58. For real-time behavior:

- Is strict real-time synchronization required, or is a near real-time/event-based model acceptable for the pilot?

JA response: Strict real-time synchronization is required for the pilot to retain the integrity and seamless running of the simulation.

59. To inform database scaling and ensure stability for 5,000 concurrent users running micro-transactions, does JA USA have an estimated transactions-per-second (TPS) peak during the active 'Business Operations' phases?

JA response: In terms of performance, JA expects the platform to handle peak activity levels efficiently. At a typical facility, there may be approximately 150 students participating, with around 30 students transacting simultaneously during shopping periods. Within a 10-minute window, this can result in roughly 500 transaction events. The system should be designed to support on the order of 50–100 transactions per second during peak load without noticeable lag or degradation in user experience.

60. Since JA USA will host the Azure DevOps project, will our developers be granted elevated permissions to configure the CI/CD pipelines, or will a JA USA DevOps engineer handle pipeline creation?

JA's response: JA BizTown developers will be granted permissions to create CI/CD pipelines.

61. Should the CMS support:

- configuration of predefined templates, or rule-based simulation logic?

JA response: The CMS should support a configuration of predefined templates determined by JA.

62. Can local JA Areas:

- configure templates only, or create new workflows?

JA response: Local JA Areas should be able to configure and create templates, but also create new workflows, including, but not limited to, creating local job tasks, businesses, and job role names.

63. Can you define the maximum technical complexity allowed for the CMS 'free space'? Are these strictly static text and image checklists, or will admins expect to build custom interactive logic?

JA response: JA envisions the "customizable free space" as a lightweight, structured way for local JA Areas to incorporate location-specific tasks into the simulation, primarily tied to their unique business sponsors and job roles.

An example of a task would be: *"Visit each business in the town and share your company's service offering with the CEO."* These tasks are intended to reinforce real-world behaviors such as communication, sales, and collaboration, and would typically occur during the Business Operations phase of the simulation.

From a functionality standpoint, this feature is expected to be simple and non-interactive. Specifically:

- Tasks will be presented as text-based instructions, with the option to include supporting images
- No complex interactivity (e.g., form inputs, branching logic, or system-driven validation) is required
- The experience should be easy for JA Area staff to configure and for students to understand quickly

In terms of flexibility, JA does want to enable local customization, but within clearly defined guardrails to maintain a consistent national experience. These include:

- Character limits to prevent overly long or complex instructions
- Predefined templates or standardized layouts to ensure visual consistency
- Basic formatting controls rather than full design freedom

Overall, the goal is to strike a balance between local relevance and national consistency, allowing Areas to add meaningful, context-specific content without introducing complexity or design variability into the student experience.

64. Do the 'unique sponsorship update requirements' for local facilities require building custom code/UI for specific sponsors, or simply swapping out logos and hex colors via the CMS?

JA response: There would not need to be custom code built for each unique sponsor. Areas would need the ability to add logos, change colors, override some text to include the business name, and utilize the customized “free space” to add any unique tasks to the business.

65. For the pilot, would it be acceptable to start with a limited set of templates and expand later?

JA response: It is acceptable to start with a limited set of templates if those limited templates provide all necessary features and functionality.

66. What is the expected technical proficiency of CMS users?

JA response: The CMS is used by JA staff who typically do not have an advanced technical background. The staff who use the CMS are commonly staff who have a focus in education and planning as opposed to technology. We expect there to be a learning curve with the creation of a new CMS, but the technology should not be so advanced that it is challenging to use for JA staff.

67. For content (tutorials, scenarios, messaging):

- Will JA provide finalized content, or should this be included in scope?

JA response: JA will provide content.

68. **Will translated content (e.g., Spanish) be provided?**

JA response: JA will look to the vendor to provide translated content.

69. For paper-based fallback:

- **Can we assume a simplified operational version, or should it fully replicate the simulation logic?**

JA response: A simplified operational version is acceptable.

70. Is this a clean-slate implementation, or should we plan to migrate historical data, configurations, or reporting datasets?

JA response: JA considers this to be a clean-slate implementation.

71. Are students treated as session-based users or persistent users across simulations?

JA response: Students who participate in the simulation will only need access to the simulation for that 3-5 hour day, so they can be treated as session-based users.

72. For reporting: should we focus on Power BI data readiness, or build in-app reporting dashboards?

JA response: The goal is to have in-app reporting dashboards - but will need to have ability to export from CMS and imported back into PowerBI

73. Are there existing KPIs or reporting structures that must be preserved?

JA response: JA USA will need to view data in an aggregate manner - and also be able to filter down individually by JA Area and by individual simulation to view data.

74. How will applications be distributed across facilities: public app stores or managed via MDM?

JA response: Both. Areas will need to download it from the app store - and also manage through their MDM.

75. What are the minimum device/OS requirements?

JA response: The smallest device used will be a tablet - no smartphones will be used to complete the simulation. Will need to function on devices that have been purchased within the past 5 years.

76. For pilot, how many JA Areas, students, and businesses should we plan to support?

JA response: The expected pilot will consist of 10-15 JA Areas, 3-5 simulations per Area, 14-20 businesses per Area, and 80-150 students per simulation.

76. Is the expectation a full-scale or controlled rollout?

JA response: The expectation is a controlled rollout to select Areas for pilot, following a full-scaled initial release, then full release.

77. During pilot simulations, is vendor support expected during live sessions, or post-session only?

JA response: Vendor is expected to be on-site, in-person during live pilot sessions.Vendor is not expected to be in person for all pilots. JA USA will work with vendor to identify pilot Areas/locations. Will also need to be available in an instant for other pilots they are not on-site.

78. Could you clarify the expected cadence for on-site collaboration across the discovery, pilot, and rollout phases?

JA response: The main in-person requirement is for the kick-off meeting and volunteering in May 2026. Will be expected to be on-site during pilot. Will be expected to be available at an instant during the first few weeks of initial release.

79. How do you envision collaboration between JA's internal teams (education, design, technology) and the vendor? Should we assume a collaborative model for this initiative, or do you envision any changes in how design ownership and decision-making will be structured?

JA response: Yes, the vendor will first provide user flows, black and white wireframe to gain consensus with the JA team on key prioritized components on the screen. JA UX/UI will provide feedback along with other stakeholders. The vendor will also provide fully developed visual designs on all templated screens. JA Visual Design lead provides feedback along with other stakeholders. In addition we reserve the right to access the source file at any time in order to provide suggestions/mockups along the way.

80. Given the RFP's emphasis on a structured design approach, we'd like to understand how you envision sequencing the work. Should we assume a phased approach across discovery, design, build, and pilot, or a more consolidated delivery model?

JA response: We expected a consolidated delivery model following the schedule of pilot, then initial release, then full release.

JA is committed to a highly collaborative and structured stakeholder engagement model throughout the JA BizTown redevelopment.

The project will begin with an in-person kickoff in May 2026, which will also include the selected vendor participating in a live JA BizTown simulation experience. This is intended to provide critical context and alignment before development begins.

Throughout the project, JA expects:

- **Weekly Working Sessions:**
  A standing 2-hour weekly meeting focused on project updates, progress reviews, and key decision points. Core JA participants will include members of the project team such as Product Ownership, Project Management, UX/UI, and other relevant contributors as needed.
- **Vendor Leadership Engagement:**
  JA expects the vendor's leadership team, not just delivery staff, to be actively involved at key milestones. This includes participation in major reviews and strategic checkpoints, as well as a recurring 30-minute leadership sync following the weekly working session to ensure alignment, escalation management, and decision-making continuity.
- **Pre-Read Expectations:**
  To ensure productive discussions, JA requests that all materials requiring review (e.g., designs, deliverables, decisions) be shared at least 24 hours in advance of scheduled meetings. This allows the JA team to come prepared with feedback and approvals.
- **In-Person Engagements:**
  While the majority of collaboration will occur virtually, JA anticipates select in-person sessions at key phases (e.g., kickoff, major milestone reviews, pilot readiness), as mutually agreed upon.
- **Roles and Availability:**
  JA will provide consistent access to key stakeholders across product, UX, content, evaluation, and technical perspectives, with engagement levels scaled based on project phase and needs.
- **Vendor Responsibilities:**
  The vendor will be expected to lead overall project orchestration, including maintaining the meeting cadence, setting agendas, documenting outcomes, and managing stakeholder sign-offs and approvals.

Overall, JA is looking for a proactive, well-organized partnership with clear communication, strong leadership alignment, and a shared commitment to delivering a high-quality product.

81. For the pilot phase, should the focus be on validating the core simulation experience and workflows, or on delivering a broader, feature-complete solution?

JA response: The core simulation experience and workflows will be proved valid during the development process with input from our advisory committee and potential end users. The pilot will deliver a broad feature complete solution.

82. To help us right-size the approach, are there any budget expectations or guardrails, particularly for the pilot phase?

JA response: See above response on budget

83. For third-party services (AI, Expo, etc.), should ongoing costs be included within the vendor scope, or managed separately by JA?

JA response: Third-party services will be managed separately by JA.

Will JA USA provide the Apple Developer Enterprise and Google Play Console accounts, or does the vendor need to initiate and manage the setup of these accounts?

JA response: If it is determined that the simulation software should be app-based, JA will provide Google Play and Apple Developer accounts.

84. From your perspective, what will differentiate a strong partner for this initiative beyond meeting the stated requirements?

JA response: In addition to everything stated in the RFP, a strong developer should have excellent planning and communication, and should bring their expertise of development, design, and product management to make the product an overall better experience. Additionally, a vendor with an education technology background and experience with the basic principles of learning design and designing for younger students would stand out.

85. Are there specific areas you plan to prioritize during evaluation (e.g., design approach, scalability, collaboration model, cost structure)?

JA response: We complete a holistic evaluation and all areas are viewed as equal.

86. For the in-person Project Kickoff and the Vendor Volunteer simulation observation, is the vendor expected to cover their own travel expenses, and what are the preferred locations for these visits?

JA Response: Travel expenses will be covered by JA and the kick off location will be determined that best meets the JA and vendor participation. Likely a JA BizTown JA Area that's convenient for the team.

87. Beyond standard operational KPIs, how will the success of the user experience specifically be measured (e.g., engagement metrics, learning outcomes, task completion rates, or ease of use)

JA response: As part of our product strategy outcomes, we must report on engagement and learning outcomes. This is a crucial part of our internal Evaluation group's responsibility and they will work with the vendor and the JA team to collect this information formally. For UX, JA

will primarily consider ease of use, engagement metrics, ease of understanding, student excitement of visuals, and above referenced learning outcomes.

88. Are you open to vendors responding as prime and including subcontractors for specified capabilities within a bid proposal?

JA response: We are not interested in bringing on subcontractors for this project.

89. To what extent will various stakeholders from Junior Achievement USA be involved throughout the process?

JA response: JA is committed to a highly collaborative and structured stakeholder engagement model throughout the JA BizTown redevelopment.

The project will begin with an in-person kickoff in May 2026, which will also include the selected vendor participating in a live JA BizTown simulation experience. This is intended to provide critical context and alignment before development begins.

Throughout the project, JA expects:

- **Weekly Working Sessions:**
  A standing 2-hour weekly meeting focused on project updates, progress reviews, and key decision points. Core JA participants will include members of the project team such as Product Ownership, Project Management, UX/UI, and other relevant contributors as needed.
- **Vendor Leadership Engagement:**
  JA expects the vendor's leadership team, not just delivery staff, to be actively involved at key milestones. This includes participation in major reviews and strategic checkpoints, as well as a recurring 30-minute leadership sync following the weekly working session to ensure alignment, escalation management, and decision-making continuity.
- **Pre-Read Expectations:**
  To ensure productive discussions, JA requests that all materials requiring review (e.g., designs, deliverables, decisions) be shared at least 24 hours in advance of scheduled meetings. This allows the JA team to come prepared with feedback and approvals.
- **In-Person Engagements:**
  While the majority of collaboration will occur virtually, JA anticipates select in-person sessions at key phases (e.g., kickoff, major milestone reviews, pilot readiness), as mutually agreed upon.
- **Roles and Availability:**
  JA will provide consistent access to key stakeholders across product, UX, content, evaluation, and technical perspectives, with engagement levels scaled based on project phase and needs.

- **Vendor Responsibilities:**
  The vendor will be expected to lead overall project orchestration, including maintaining the meeting cadence, setting agendas, documenting outcomes, and managing stakeholder sign-offs and approvals.

Overall, JA is looking for a proactive, well-organized partnership with clear communication, strong leadership alignment, and a shared commitment to delivering a high-quality product.

90. Will the selected vendor be collaborating with the same group of stakeholders for the duration of this project?

JA response: Yes, the core team for this project will remain consistent.

91. Will this internal group be responsible for presenting deliverables and collecting feedback from additional stakeholders within the organization?

JA response: The JA USA team is responsible for presenting deliverables and collecting feedback from stakeholders, including, but not limited to JA Area staff, educators, and students.

92. Will you please share more about the “Personalization" aspect of the Product Design Expectations section within the shared requirements?

JA response: By this, we meant that some roles or businesses have customization, but we do not mean personalization at the individual level. Personalization of businesses including business name, logos, jobs, and tasks.

93. What are the top 3 outcomes you'll use to define "success" for the updated BizTown platform, and what criteria will weigh most heavily in vendor selection?

JA response: The top 3 outcomes JA will use to define success are (1) the defined student learning objectives are met, (2) the software proves a seamless, reliable real-time simulation experience, (3) the product is a scalable national platform with controlled local customization.

JA completed a holistic evaluation of vendors and each stated requirement is weighed evenly.

94. Is this a complete greenfield build, or is there existing data/content that needs to be migrated from the current simulation software? If so, can you provide documentation of the current system's architecture and data model?

JA response: JA considers this project a complete greenfield build.

95. What is the target budget range for this project? Understanding the investment envelope will help us propose the most impactful phased approach.

JA response: see previous response about budget

96. The timeline shows "JA Area Training & Site Prep" beginning Nov 2026, before the Jan 2027 pilot. What level of product completeness is expected by Nov 2026? Are the stated project deadlines fixed, or is there flexibility?

JA response: A full, completed product is expected for the January 2027 pilot. In November 2026, we expect most of the product to be completed to be able to share with pilot Areas.

97. How do you see MVP pilot vs final product release? What features are must-haves for launch, and what can be planned for later phases? What is JA's tolerance for a phased rollout?

JA response: JA pilots are designed to be completed with the full product with time allotted after the pilot for needed changes and updates. A full-scale rollout is the goal as these pilots will be completed in real simulation spaces with students, volunteers, educators, and staff.

98. Is a staged rollout across locations required or optional, and can different locations operate on different versions simultaneously?

JA response: The pilot will be a planned rollout with 10-15 JA Areas. During the initial release, Areas will have the option to choose to use the new simulation or the existing simulation. During the full release, all Areas will be asked to use the new simulation.

99. Can JA provide access to observe a current simulation day before the May 2026 kickoff date?

JA response: This may be able to be arranged depending on the location of the vendor and proximity to a JA Area who is running JA BizTown.

100. Which internal team members and roles (Product Manager, UI Designer, etc.) will collaborate with the selected vendor on the product development?

JA response: The vendor will collaborate with the core JA USA team including the Product Owner, Product Manager, UX/UX Team, Content Team, Technology Team, and Evaluation Team.

101. The simulation day schedule includes multiple phases (orientation, trainings, operations rounds, debrief, state of town). Which phases are hardest operationally today and need the most software support?

JA response: The phases of the simulation day that will need the most software integration and support are the Business Operations phases. During this time, students will be completing their tasks, selling products, purchasing products, voting, paying the business loan, sending and paying bills, etc.

Although this phase has that most software integration, each phase in the day will have software reliance.

102. What artifacts currently define the simulation logic (e.g., rulebooks, process flows, system specifications)?

JA response: Currently, process flows are what determine the simulation logic.

103. Are there any undocumented simulation rules or behaviors currently used in practice?

JA response: There are not.

104. Which components of the simulation are strictly fixed and cannot be changed. Which components are open to redesign or simplification?

JA response: The simulation flow is planned and designed by JA and is fixed. JA is open to developer input regarding the means to arrive at the end goals that have been stated in the RFP.

105. What are the primary success criteria for the simulation, and which metric determines success at launch (incl. any measurable KPIs)?

JA response: The top 3 outcomes JA will use to define success are (1) the defined student learning objectives are met, (2) the software proves a seamless, reliable real-time simulation experience, (3) the product is a scalable national platform with controlled local customization.

106. Should the simulation adapt difficulty for elementary vs middle school students? If yes, which modules vary?

JA response: No, the simulation will remain that same for 5th and 6th grade students.

107. Which onboarding flows must be implemented within the product, and are interactive tutorials required within the application?

JA response: It is expected that the simulation should not require extensive onboarding and tutorials. For tasks such as POS System, Billing, Loan Payments, and Billing, there should be guided step by step tutorials during the first instance of completing the task.

108. The RFP references "two simulations targeted at different audiences" (p.34). Can you clarify what the second simulation is, whether it is in scope for this RFP, and what the key differences are?

JA response: It has been determined that there will be one simulation that is targeted for 5th and 6th grade students.

109. Which specific regulations must the system comply with (e.g., FERPA, COPPA), including any region-specific legal requirements and internal policies?

JA response: This should not be an issue as we will not be asking students for email addresses or any other personal identifying information.

110. Regarding COPPA compliance and student data privacy - what is JA's current approach to parental consent, data retention, and deletion for minors? Should the vendor include compliance architecture in the proposal?

JA response: Parental consent requirements rest with schools. JA retains the data indefinitely. There should be an anonymization process that runs after a simulation reaches a certain age (for example 30 days). This should be included in the proposal.

111. Which user actions must be logged for audit purposes, what level of detail is required, and how long must audit logs be retained?

JA response: All admin functions should be audited and kept for 30 days. This includes who completed the function, what the function was, and when it occurred. User actions should be set to be logged for troubleshooting purposes and kept for a maximum of 7 days.

112. What is the expected device ownership and management model (JA-owned tablets vs facility-sourced)? What MDM solution is in place, and what are the minimum device specs? Does each participant should have device to participate in simulation?

JA response: Each local JA Area owns their own devices. These range from laptops and chromebooks to Android tablets and iPads. Each JA Area determines their own MDM solution; some have MDMs and some do not. Each participant should have a device to participate in the simulation.

113. Are JA Areas responsible for procuring their own tablets and payment scanners, or will JA USA standardize hardware across all sites?

JA response: JA Area are responsible for procuring all of their own hardware and devices. There is not an exact standard across all Areas.

114. Will tablets serve as the primary device for student interactions during onsite simulations, or will there be a combination of laptops, Chromebooks, iPads, and Android tablets depending on the specific JA Area? Is running the application on mobile phones also considered?

JA response: Yes, tablets will serve as the main device for student interactions, but there will also be Area who continue to use their laptops, so the software should be flexible to that instance. The simulation will not be run on mobile phones.

115. What is the network infrastructure at typical JA BizTown facilities? Specifically: bandwidth, Wi-Fi capacity for 150+ simultaneous tablet connections, and any existing network hardware standards.

JA response: A typical facility will have bandwidth of 100 Mbps download and 80 Mbps upload. Many exceed this requirement. For WiFi they will have the capability of handling 1 device per student in the facility (facility sizes differ - with some reaching upwards of 210 students). Device manufacturers are not mandated by JA USA.

116. How is authentication established in the existing software? What Identity Provider & SSO technology (e.g., Microsoft Entra ID/Azure AD, Okta, Ping) is in use and preferred?

JA response: Currently we're using Identify Server 4 to authenticate per device. However, we may want students to use a simpler authentication method.

117. How are student accounts created in the system?

JA response: Currently, student accounts are not created. The simulation contains the amalgamation of businesses and job roles. Students are connected to a job role during the payroll process when the CFO types the student name in and selects their job role. We are open to other processes for this, but would like to continue not needing individual student accounts.

118. What authentication methods are required for students and what security level is required (e.g., QR/PIN), including device sharing / impersonation prevention expectations?

JA response: Currently we're using Identify Server 4 to authenticate per device. However, we may want students to use a simpler authentication method.

119. What is the acceptable latency for real-time interactions, and which parts of the system must operate in real time?

JA response: All transactions should operate in real time, including payroll, POS, billing, loan application and payment, student accounts, business accounts, etc. Real time interactions should be instant.

120. Which operations require strong consistency across users/systems vs. which can tolerate eventual consistency? How should data conflicts be resolved?

JA response: We expect consistency across all systems. We expect each user, company and transaction to be unique and do not expect there to be data conflicts.

121. Are business transactions in simulations allowed to be deleted or edited; and is an immutable audit trail required (and for which events / who can access logs)?

JA response: Business transactions in simulations should be able to be cancelled by JA Admin. There should be a log of all business transactions and personal transactions in the simulation. Businesses (students and volunteers) should be able to see all of their business transactions. JA Admin should be able to see all transactions for all students and businesses. These details may need to be kept as a report - but audit trails for individual student transactions do not need to be kept.

122. What specific reports must be generated for students, businesses, and simulations?

JA response: For students, the report should show their finances, transactions, voting, job role, XPs. For businesses, the report should show their financial status, transactions (billing, POS, loan payments), XPs. For simulations, the report should list all of that data for each business.

123. In what formats should reports be delivered?

JA response: Reports should be delivered in a sharable PDF format and available on the staff dashboard using easy to read and captivating visuals.

124. What data must be excluded due to privacy constraints, and are aggregated reports sufficient for certain use cases?

JA response: We follow COPPA and do not collect personal information for students under 13. Personal information should be restructured.

125. What are the expected peak usage hours across time zones, and how many concurrent users must the system support at peak?

JA response: Peak hours are generally 9AM ET to 3PM PT - with peak times around 10am-2pm EST. We would expect the system to be designed to support 10 - 15K concurrent users.

126. How many simulations are expected to run simultaneously?

JA response: We should plan for 60-70 simulations running simultaneously.

127. What sponsor interactions must be tracked within the system, what metrics must be reported to sponsors, and are there compliance restrictions related to sponsor tracking?

JA response: The system should track the number of students working in each business each day to provide sponsors with a yearly total, "options" that students picked the most, typical sales price of product/service, and marketing/advertisement created.

128. Regarding CMS & Configuration (National vs Local):

1. **Which configurations must be controlled centrally vs customized locally?**
2. **How should conflicts between global templates and local overrides be handled (precedence / manual vs automated)?**
3. **Who has authority to override configurations?**

JA response: We will detail which configurations are available at the local level via the national level. If a local configuration item is customizable then the local level takes precedence. If the local configuration item is not customizable, then national takes precedence.

JA USA National Education staff have the authority to override configurations.

129. Should we consider third-party product integrations that your organization may already be using? What existing integrations does JA maintain (LMS for pre-simulation curriculum, volunteer management, ERP, CRM, school data systems)?

JA response: If an existing integrations are required JA will share the necessary API information to integrate.

130. The requirement for stored procedures for all database queries — is this a firm constraint, or would JA consider a hybrid approach if the vendor can justify the technical benefits?

JA response: We would consider modifying this if there is adequate justification for the exception.

131. The RFP requires screen-sharing (e.g., the CFO completing a business loan application while teammates watch on their devices). Could you clarify:

1. **Is this a real-time screen mirror, or is synchronized application state acceptable?**

2. **Where should the shared screen be displayed?**
    1. **Only on *other students' tablets within the same business*,**
    2. **Or also on *large facility displays*, projectors, or wall-mounted monitors?**
    3. **Should Simulation Managers have a "broadcast to all" capability for demonstrations?**

JA response: JA envisions this feature as a real-time screen-sharing experience, where the CFO's device is effectively mirrored to other team members so they can observe the loan application process as it is being completed.

This capability should support multiple concurrent sessions, with the expectation that each business within the simulation (approximately 14–20 per facility) may be running its own screen-sharing session simultaneously.

The feature must function reliably within a typical facility WiFi environment. While JA will work to ensure adequate network infrastructure, the solution should be designed with resilience in mind, accounting for potential variability in connectivity and bandwidth. Vendors are encouraged to consider approaches that optimize performance under these conditions (e.g., efficient streaming, low-latency updates, or alternative architectures that achieve a similar real-time shared experience).

From a user perspective, the experience should be seamless and require minimal setup or intervention from students or staff.

While JA has described this as a screen-mirroring experience, we are open to alternative technical approaches, such as shared state views, if they can deliver the same real-time visibility, reliability, and ease of use within the simulation environment.

132. Should screen-sharing support audio narration (e.g., CFO explaining steps), or is this prohibited due to loud/noisy facility environments?

JA response: No audio narration should be included. The facility environments would not allow for this to be successful.

133. Is any functionality required to work without internet connectivity; which features must be available offline; and is data synchronization required after reconnection (incl. conflict resolution)?

JA response: JA recognizes that reliable real-time transaction processing is critical to the JA BizTown simulation, particularly during high-activity periods, and that facility WiFi conditions may vary.

The system is expected to support offline-capable or “local-first” operation with eventual synchronization. Student devices should be able to continue key activities (e.g., purchases, deposits, payments) even in the event of temporary connectivity disruptions, with data syncing seamlessly once connectivity is restored. At the same time, JA is not expecting or requiring a traditional on-premise/local server solution; vendors should propose architectures that balance resilience with a cloud-based or hybrid approach.

From a consistency standpoint, the system should prioritize accuracy and reconciliation across all entities, including student checking accounts, business accounts, and financial institution dashboards, once synchronization occurs. The user experience should remain smooth and intuitive, with minimal visible disruption during transient network issues.

In terms of performance, JA expects the platform to handle peak activity levels efficiently. At a typical facility, there may be approximately 150 students participating, with around 30 students transacting simultaneously during shopping periods. Within a 10-minute window, this can result in roughly 500 transaction events. The system should be designed to support on the order of 50–100 transactions per second during peak load without noticeable lag or degradation in user experience.

Overall, the expectation is a highly responsive, resilient system that maintains data integrity while accommodating real-world network variability across all JA locations.

134. For the paper-based fallback — is this a full parallel paper simulation, or a simplified backup covering core activities? What exactly must be printable as PDFs, and how should reconciliation work once systems return?

JA response: If the simulation can run in an offline environment, a paper-based fallback is not required.

135. The digital marketing tool is "Canva-like" — what's the minimum viable feature set (templates, shapes, image library)? Can you clarify the intended scope to avoid feature creep?

JA response: JA envisions the “Canva-like” digital marketing tool as a guided, age-appropriate design experience rather than a fully open-ended or professional-grade design platform. The focus is on enabling students to successfully create a simple, effective advertisement within the context of the simulation.

The minimum viable features for this tool include:

- A structured, step-by-step “design mission” that guides students through the creation process and ensures their advertisement includes key elements (e.g., business name, slogan, visual, and clear message).

- A template-based design approach, where students select from pre-built layouts rather than creating designs from scratch.
- The ability to add and edit text, including at minimum their business name and AI-generated or student-created slogan.
- The ability to select or change background images or simple design elements.
- Access to a curated asset library of images, with the ability for JA Area administrators to upload and manage assets via the CMS.

From a functionality standpoint, the tool should prioritize ease of use, clarity, and speed over advanced design capabilities such as complex layering, precision editing, or fully freeform drag-and-drop systems.

Regarding sharing, JA's primary requirement is that students can easily publish or display their final advertisement within the simulation so it can be viewed by other participants (e.g., displayed digitally throughout the town experience). We are flexible on the technical approach to achieve this and do not require real-time collaboration. A simple and reliable publish or export-and-display workflow is sufficient for the MVP.

Overall, the goal is to provide a lightweight, intuitive tool that supports learning objectives and creativity without introducing unnecessary complexity.

136. Are the AI features (slogan generation, speech transcription) hard requirements for the pilot, or can they be introduced post-launch?

JA response: This is something can be discussed depending on the other features that are available for the pilot.

137. The RFP states that the system must support debit cards and debit-card swipers. Should these be:

1. **Fully simulated virtual cards only,**
2. **Or do you expect the system to support *real* physical debit card hardware interactions? (This affects hardware procurement, SDK integrations, and PCI compliance.)**

JA response: In the current version of the simulation, the system supports physical debit cards. The debit cards are coded with the student three digit account number and when the card is swiped, the student account number populates in the POS system.

138. Should NFC payments be implemented as:

1. **A simulated "tap-to-pay" event with no actual NFC secure element usage?**
2. **Or should the solution integrate with *actual* NFC hardware capabilities on tablets/phones? (Real NFC support significantly impacts device selection and security requirements.)**

JA response: JA anticipates that facilities will be equipped with a mix of iOS and Android tablets, many of which will have built-in NFC capabilities. Additionally, some locations may choose to procure simple external NFC readers that can connect to tablets or computers, depending on their specific setup.

At this time, NFC functionality is considered a **nice-to-have enhancement rather than a core requirement** for the JA BizTown simulation. Vendors are encouraged to explore its feasibility and potential value within the experience, but it is not required for the MVP.

Given the variability in device types and configurations across JA locations, any proposed NFC solution should account for cross-platform compatibility (iOS and Android) and differing hardware capabilities. Flexibility and graceful degradation (e.g., alternative payment methods) will be important to ensure a consistent experience across all sites.

139. Should the mobile and web experiences be delivered as fully separate applications, or do you expect a unified codebase where both share logic/UI? (For instance, relying solely on a web frontend within a mobile WebView may result in suboptimal user experience. Do you intend to avoid this?)

JA response: We don't expect both a mobile and a web application. The software should run seamlessly on one or the other.

140. Should tablet orientation be locked (portrait/landscape) during simulation to prevent accidental UI disruptions?

JA response: The UI should function in both portrait and landscape view as some students may be working from computers.

141. Do you expect support for Bluetooth accessories (thermal printers, barcode scanners, external card readers, etc.)?

JA response: Any accessories most likely will be hardwired, but this is something we can consider.

142. Do JA Areas frequently create custom visual assets (logos, sponsor images)? If so, what file sizes and formats must we support?

JA response: JA Areas are frequently adding their local sponsor logos and visual assets to the CMS to then be populated in the simulation. The vendor can dictate the size and format that is used.

143. Disaster recovery:

1. What is the required RTO (Recovery Time Objective) and RPO (Recovery Point Objective)?
2. Is full state recovery required after system failure? Is partial data loss acceptable?
3. Should simulations resume from the exact previous state after failure? Is restarting a simulation acceptable in certain scenarios?

JA response: JA would expect that the system will gracefully handle contention between transactions. We would expect latency thresholds to be in the low seconds (1-2). A full state recovery is expected after system failure. Simulations should resume from the exact previous state after failure. Restarting a simulation is not acceptable.